

froggy

June 29– © typeface by Chris Lozos

Inspired by a Typophile Battle Week involving ligature madness with Cooper Black. Froggy was my double “g” ligature carried on to something else, a semi-serif.

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Plunk your magic twanger, Froggy!

Hiya, kids, Hiya, hiya!

The Buster Brown TV Show with Smilin' Ed McConnell and his Buster Brown Gang (later the title was mercifully shortened to 'Smilin' Ed's Gang').

11 point:

This NBC Saturday evening children's series was sponsored by Buster Brown shoes starting in 1950, and was basically a TV version of McConnell's popular and long-running radio program (1944-1952).

The backdrop was a clubhouse, with kids in the studio audience. Produced on a very small budget, the show was a success—bringing the Buster Brown advertising characters to life and helping to sell millions of shoes based on icons that had existed for decades. It was also one of the first kid shows filmed in Hollywood.

The folksy broadcast was hosted by old-timer Smilin' Ed McConnell; music and stories from Smilin' Ed's Storybook were regular features. The show also featured "Gunga, the East India Boy," a serial set in India. Led by The Maharajah, Gunga Ram and his pal Rama set out on great adventures around the village of Bakore in filmed segments.

The most popular segment was the visit from Froggy the Gremlin who would appear when Smilin' Ed yelled his famous catch-phrase, "Plunk your Magic Twanger, Froggy!" Don't ask me what a 'Magic Twanger' was!

The Smilin' Ed Show was moved to Saturday mornings in 1951, where it ran on CBS and ABC (as 'Smilin' Ed's Gang') until 1954 when the Ed McConnell died suddenly of a heart attack.

And alot of that money was due to the "Buster Brown Show" and Froggy the Gremlin. For this show, Ed had the right sponsor, and great support from producer Frank Ferrin, writer Hobart Donavan (who also wrote the Buster Brown comic book giveaways) and director Arthur Jacobson.

When Ed started his hit kiddie show, radio audiences knew Buster Brown faintly...from a 1929 radio series on CBS. By the time Smilin Ed' got his kiddie show, Buster Brown was no longer well remembered as a comic strip, the character was merely the trademark symbol for a shoe company.

Buster Brown and Smilin' Ed collided in 1944, with "Smilin' Ed's Buster Brown Gang" taking to the airwaves on September 2nd. The show continued on NBC radio every Saturday morning at 11:30 through April 11, 1953.

The format rarely varied. There was an adventure story to open the show, a lot of plugs for Buster Brown shoes,

and finally towards the end, Froggy the Gremlin might sing a song or annoy a guest (such as Shortfellow the Poet or Alkali Pete the Cowboy). Midnight the Cat actually spoke a few lines now and then, and Smilin' Ed was always prone to sing a novelty song (or two).

Yes, Ed would invite Froggy to come out and make make himself visible by plunking his magic twanger!

"Plunking" may have come from Ed's habit of plunking the strings on his piano to emphasize some of the action in his stories. (The piano was actually named "Grandy the Piano," as if it was alive.)

Ed was the voice of Froggy, putting on a low, gruff, Popeye-like croak.

However...whenever Ed had to sing a duet WITH Froggy, announcer Archie Presby was the voice of Froggy. And when there was a live audience, Archie would sometimes dress up in a frog costume and carry on to the delight of the screaming kids.

Presby was a staff announcer for NBC. Back in 1937 he performed his duties on a radio variety show called "Bughouse Rhythm." Variety reviewed the show and noted: "Program is nicely laid out, in that quaint croaking narrator, G. Archibald Presby, treats each (jazz) player with dignity...all are introduced and referred to as 'Mr.'"

The full cast of the radio show included June Foray, Wendall Noble, Conrad Binyon, John Dehner and Jimmy Ogg. They took part in the adventure stories. June was called upon to voice Midnight and Bud Tollefson, the sound effects engineer, growled the voice of Tige the Dog.

Smilin' Ed used the show to promote not only the Buster Brown shoes, but the comic books, which featured Ed and usually a little story involving the "Buster Brown Gang" of Midnight, Squeaky and Froggy. To his credit, Ed would tell the kiddies that

they could go to their local store and get a comic book WITHOUT having to make a purchase!

FROGGY THE GREMLIN

He made people look stupid.

He laughed at "squares."

He perfected "mind control" and "subliminal suggestion" before the Cold War era began.

He jeered authority and cheered humorous disobedience. He only had kind words for his cult followers:

"Hiya kids, hiya hiya."

While Moe had Larry & Curly, and Spike Jones had his City Slickers, Froggy the Gremlin worked alone. That's part of why he has such a unique one-to-one appeal in our memory. He was the lone class clown, the one "bad apple" in the barrel, the one wart on the helping hand.

Remember when you were a kid, and adults kept giving you another chance to be good and behave? On "Andy's Gang," Andy Devine, that big symbol of authority, invited the Gremlin to come out and behave himself... "Plunk Your Magic Twanger, Froggy!"

In a puff of smoke, Froggy appeared, laughing, hopping from side to side, that fixed and evil grin on his face.

Andy thought THIS TIME, Froggy might behave like a responsible adult. But the kids in the audience knew

better! Froggy relished practical jokes, dirty tricks, and interrupting any “guest” who was giving a lecture that involved learning something! In the audience, kids screamed with delight, half of them howling and trying to get out of their seats.

The history of Froggy the Gremlin is a swamp of mystery. Nobody paid much attention to kiddie shows, so there aren’t any newspaper clippings about Froggy. By the time people realized how warped Froggy was, the program was over, the damage was done and the perpetrators long dead.

The legend began on radio.

Froggy made his debut in a kiddie show hosted by Smilin’ Ed McConnell. He was the Father of Froggy, pleasant, jolly and full of fun and fantasies.

When Smilin’ Ed unveiled his “Buster Brown Gang” show in 1944, audiences didn’t know what to expect. Buster Brown had been the subject of a brief 1929 radio series on CBS, and that was now a dim memory. And so was R. F. Outcault, who had died in 1928.

R.F. Outcault (1863-1928) was the cartoonist who created the Buster Brown strip in 1902. It debuted in the New York Herald.

You want me to get back to the story of Froggy. OK. Smilin’ Ed’s show was a hit. He’d be sure to open every episode with a subliminal shoe reference (“Come running”) and pepper the show with references to his one and only sponsor.

Frank Ferren was the producer and Hobart Donovan was the officially credited writer. He definitely wrote the long “adventure” scripts that took up most of the show’s half hour. But it seems that the novelty songs were written by Smilin’ Ed, and the comical segments with Froggy the Gremlin were done by Harry Stewart, a struggling cornball comedian who was

slowly beginning a career as a novelty singer and character comic under the name Yogi Yorgesson.

The characters of Froggy the Gremlin, Midnight the Cat and Squeaky the Mouse were not in the Buster Brown strip; they were all invented for the radio show.

“Smilin’ Ed’s Buster Brown Gang” took to the airwaves on September 2nd. His long run on NBC radio would continue every Saturday morning at 11:30 through April 11, 1953.

The Buster Brown comic books, given out free, eventually began to feature not only adventure stories, but funny adventures involving Smilin’ Ed and his Gang.

As with the latter TV show adventures (featuring Gunga Ram) the radio and comic book adventures involving kid heroes, genies and pirates were not exactly riveting. Today it’s Froggy the Gremlin that accounts for most of the interest in the radio show, comic books and TV series.

For many kids, a sign of puberty was getting sick of that Buster Brown label inside your shoe and wanting to wear a normal brand of footwear.

Into the harmless world of radio adventure stories and Buster Brown comic books came a certain amphibian-poltergeist. He was dressed, mockingly, in a red jacket, white shirt and black tie. But he had no pants on.

Was he a ghost, space creature or leprechaun? A little guy with a frog’s head?

Was he a frog that became a gremlin? A gremlin that had become a frog? Where exactly was his “twanger” and how did he “plunk” it? Nobody really knew much about the magical, mysterious.....

FROGGY THE GREMLIN.

He was the star attraction. Eventually he appeared on many Buster Brown comic book covers, and.....

By 1948 the Rempel Company began to market a Froggy the Gremlin. Yes, he was now infiltrating homes.

While the Froggy doll remains the most sought-after item for Gremlin-philes, there is a lot of other stuff out there.

If you'd like a close-up on the feet... clickity-click! And for children who want to actually BE the mischievous gremlin, a paper Froggy mask...

\$50 for the mask is not uncommon. What would a simple piece of cardboard with a "froggy flicker" image on it cost at an Internet auction?

Those who visited a Buster Brown store may have been confronted by a bizarre "in store" display. Three dimensional, motorized so that the figures actually moved, the wooden stage (five feet by three feet) must have made kids gasp and parents cringe. Let's test your reaction...

Highly prized: the box the shoes came in, because Froggy was on the box (he was, he was)...

REMEMBERING BUSTER BROWN'S ORIGIN AND COMIC BOOK FROGGY

by Ronald L. Smith

Here's more than you'll ever want to know about the origin of Buster Brown shoes and the creation of the Buster Brown comic strip....

In 1878, George Warren Brown and Alvin Bryan started the Bryan, Brown and Company manufacturing plant in St. Louis. Their big product was Brown Shoes, and in 1893 that became the company name. That's about as dull and plain as a brown shoe gets.

Meanwhile, in 1902, a fellow named Richard F. Outcault was launching a new comic strip in New York. (That's

Outcault at the top of this page). The hero would be a sort of sissified kid named Buster Brown. Why? Because the successful OLD comic strip had come under fire for being too nasty. The lead character was a kind of Bart Simpson brat known as The Yellow Kid.

As you can see, the nasty brat was enough of a legend to eventually become immortalized on a U.S. postage stamp.

But back around the turn of the century, The Yellow Kid had run afoul of bluenoses, and that was interfering with Outcault earning his green. Some wordsmiths insist that the term "yellow journalism" came from "the yellow papers," the newspapers sleazy enough to carry the appalling antics of The Yellow Kid.

The Yellow Kid, like subsequent blond brats Dennis the Menace and Bart Simpson, had become a great marketing item. Only instead of t-shirts, The Yellow Kid turned up hawking such adult products as beer and alcohol!

Outcault finally gave in and decided to create a new kid hero, an upscale boy with a milder streak of mischief. Think: The Yellow Kid is to the Three Stooges what Buster Brown is to The Cosby Show.

As you can see, Buster was quite a different fellow from the notorious Yellow Kid. Outcault had success with this new character and in 1904 went out to St. Louis for the World's Fair, intent on marketing the new character for ads, posters, and any other product he could find.

The fair, which had its own theme song in "Meet Me in St. Louis" was a rousing success and amid the greed and merriment Richard Outcault, Buster Brown hawker, met up with George Warren Brown, Brown Shoe maker. It was a perfect fit.

Of all the licenses Outcault sold, the one to the Brown Shoe company proved the most lucrative. The Brown

Shoe Company took an aggressive marketing approach for their new Buster Brown line. They hired short people (at the time, the term was “midgets”) to impersonate Buster Brown at stores and theaters. Sometimes Buster Brown brought along his dog Tige and an entire cast for shows. That type of thing definitely brought the rubes ‘a running. The idea was so successful that the idea of a grown-up Buster was continued throughout the run of Smilin’ Ed and Andy’s Gang on TV, Buster Brown was played not by a child, but by an adult, Jerry Narron.

For many, Jerry’s squealing commercial that begins “I’m Buster Brown, I live in a shoe...” still resonates....

10 point

That you can put your foot into The “Buster Brown” shoe line still exists, but the Brown Shoe Company rakes in \$1.6 billion in sales with the help of other brands such as Naturalizer, LifeStride and Connie shoes for women.

In 2002 NPR radio’s Morning Edition celebrated the 100 year anniversary of the Outcault strip. Reporter Elizabeth Blair described the series this way: “In almost every strip, Buster Brown wore short pants, a little jacket, and dainty Victorian shoes and sometimes a wide, saucer-rimmed hat. His family was rich, which appealed to upper class New Yorkers.”

At the end of his adventures, Buster Brown would often insist: ‘I’m sorry I was bad, I promise never to do that again, I’ll be a good boy from now on.’

Yes, Froggy the Gremlin’s “I’ll be good, I will, I will,” came directly from Buster Brown.

“Buster Brown Comics” may be a thing of the past, but Froggy in a comic book is MUCH more lively. There are many many issues of the underground Zero Zero comic book featuring bizarre adventures involving Smilin’ Ed and Froggy, courtesy of Kim Deitch.

Here’s a photo of Kim posing with Froggy, September of 2002

9 point

Kim emerged along with R. Crumb, Spain, Bill Griffith and others when he was part of the underground comic scene circa 1970. His wonderfully pornographic work appeared in such classics as “Insect Fear” and “Clean Wholesome Tales of Sex and Death.”

And many years later, 1997 to be precise, he decided to create a series about Smilin’ Ed and Froggy. (Although he had used “Smilin’ Ed” as the name for a freak show back in a comic strip in 1970).

And many can
probably sing
that gently lilting
Buster Brown
shoe song...

**Does your shoe have a dog inside?
What a funny place for a dog to hide
Does your shoe have a boy there too
A boy and a dog and a foot in a shoe
well the boy is buster brown
And the dog is Tige his friend.
And its really just a picture
But its fun to play pretend!
So look, look, look
In your telephone book
For the store that sells the shoe, with the
picture of the boy and the dog inside too!**